Mindfulness of Breath: Establishing an Anchor #2

Further Notes on Leading a Meditation

Here are some additional recommendations for leading a meditation. These are suggestions, not rigid instructions.

Stagecraft Tend the space, the light, temperature, sound, and chairs.

Comfort Make sure they are comfortable in the body—grounded, steady, at ease.

Voice Talk slowly and clearly, with appropriate pauses.

Orienting First, direct them to open their attention—to gently note their surroundings and then draw the attention back to themselves.

Invitation Invite them to now use their breath to quiet their mind and tend their body and heart.

Time Together, set an intention to sit for 5, 10, or 20 minutes.

Eyes Suggest they close their eyes or leave them half open.

Your Eyes Keep your eyes open and pay attention to both inner and outer at the same time.

Sense the Body Have them first sense their body seated as they are.

Start Where You Are Remind them to start exactly where they are and feel the breath/anchor in the midst of it all.

A Few Deep Breaths Start with a few deeper, cleansing breaths.

Next After the deep breaths have ended, have them notice how the breath breathes itself.

Notice Wherever the breath is most clear—nose, throat, chest, belly, or full body.

Anchors Acknowledge that some may be using alternative anchors.

Adding Phrases or Numbers For those who wish, they can softly note in the background "calm" or "ease" with each breath, or note an anchor. They can also whisper to themselves, "Count one through ten."

Returning to the Breath Remind them that returning is the key. Return to the breath/anchor 1000 times gently and directly like training the puppy.

Distractions Let other experiences rise and fall like waves of the ocean around the breath/anchor. Whether sounds, sensations, thoughts, plans, emotions, or anything else, for now let them be in the background and steadily feel the breath breathe itself or the anchor in the midst of it all.

Noticing Calm and Steadiness Have them look for any positive moments of calm, steadiness, ease, concentration, or peace that arise. Have them inhabit/rest/dwell in these while they are present.

Refining Attention Further instruction can invite them to notice the beginning, middle, and end of each breath.

Another Refinement You can invite them to notice and rest in the space between the breaths.

Ending Announcement Sometimes it helps to say, "One more minute."

[Gently ring the bell to close.]